



district.

The first phase of the project is expected to be completed by mid-2023. The state government has instructed the Forest Department to plant trees along the total length of the Ram Van Gaman Path measuring approximately 2260 Km., which will not only serve as beautification of the route, but is also a gesture and step towards developing a green environment along the circuit.

The Nine Destinations in Phase 1

Sitamarhi – Harchauka, literally means Mata Sita's kitchen. It is known for the huge cave that has been carved by cutting stones and has an important religious history. The ancient rock cave has 17 rooms where one can find installations of 12 Shivalings. Also, the first destination of Lord Ram in Chhattisgarh was Sitamarhi Harchauka located in the Koriya district.

The village is located at the banks of the Mawai River.

According to the local legends, a big boulder in this place bears the footprints of Lord Ram.

Ramgarh, is one of the most ancient historical spots in Surguja and is replete with cultural, historical, and archaeological significance. Interestingly, the world's oldest theatre is said to be located here in the Sitabengra-Jogimara Caves. The name Sitabengra is derived from the name of Mata Sita, who had stayed here with her husband Lord Ram during exile. Not only did the great poet Kalidasa compose his magnum opus Meghadootam here, but the oldest rock theatre in the Sitabengra-Jogimara caves, dating back to the third century B.C., is also located here. The latter still has inscriptions from the Mauryan and Gupta periods. One can soak in the ancient culture and historical importance of Ramgarh by visiting this

place from history.

Shivrinarayan (Janjgir Champa), is probably the most significant spot in the entire Ram Van Gaman Tourism Circuit because it is located at the foothills of the Maikal mountain range and the junction of the three holy rivers - Mahanadi, Jonk, and Shivrinarayan. It is named after the sacred meeting place of Mata Shabri and Lord Narayan (Lord Ram). According to legends, Lord Ram and Lakshman had come here to meet Mata Shabri, who had lovingly fed them with wild berry fruits. Although she had herself tasted the fruits to discern their sweetness before offering them to Lord Ram, the latter had happily accepted them. Many temples in Shivrinarayan are relevant from a historical and cultural standpoint. Important among them are the Shivrinarayan Temple dedicated to Mata Shabri, Nar Narayan Temple, Jagannath Temple, and Keshav Narayan Temple. All these temples in Shivrinarayan are worth visiting for those interested in Indian mythology. The town also hosts a grand fair during Magh Purnima every year. Adventure seekers can also enjoy various water sports at the Mahanadi River.

Turturiya, is a small village nestled in the forests in the Balodabazar district of Chhattisgarh. It is said that the great sage Valmiki, who wrote the epic Ramayana, had his Ashram here. Moreover, Lord Ram and Mata Sita's twin sons Luv-Kush were also born here. The place gets its distinct name from the water of the Balbhadri drain, as it strikes the rocks on its way and makes the sound tur-tur. There are many sites worth visiting in Turturiya. This quaint village is famous for its Buddhist ruins that consist of exquisitely-carved pillars and stupas constructed with bricks. The place also has the unique idols of four-armed Lord Vishnu and Lord Ganesha. Additionally, Turturiya is also surrounded by a verdant landscape with an effulgence of natural beauty. A grand festival is held in this nondescript town of Turturiya from Vaishakh

